

over a familiar foe via unanimous decision (50-45, 50-45, 50-44). The American not only completed his maiden title defence but did it in some style, outsmarting Vera in every department.

The fighters exchanged blows to inflict identical damage on each other in the first round, and there was little to set them apart. O'Malley's moment of brilliance came at the end of the second round when he landed a step-in knee—the kind that would've knocked out any other fighter, but Vera stood his ground. The hit was so powerful that O'Malley acknowledged it in the post-match interview. "I felt something in his face break," O'Malley said of the move. "I don't know if it was his nose or cheek. I felt something snap."

The switch stance — when a fighter switches from an orthodox to a southpaw stance or vice versa — was on full display from both ends, but O'Malley used it cleverly to gain the upper hand. The champion kept mixing his position throughout the fight, sending blows to all quadrants of the torso.

From then on, it was an all-out O'Malley show, as he showcased a blend of efficiency, poise, and precision to cement his place at the top.

An eventful main card

Former interim lightweight champion and future UFC Hall of Famer Dustin Poirier knocked out the surging Benoit Saint-Denis with a right hand in the second round of their lightweight bout. Saint-Denis had hurt Poirier with punches in the early round before the veteran dropped him with a right hook at 2:52 in the second round. The victory moved Poirier into a tie for the fourth-most wins (22) in UFC history.

Earlier, Jack Della Maddalena stretched his winning streak to 17 with the biggest victory of his career. He stopped Gilbert Burns in the third round of their bout with a crushing knee to the head, moments after it appeared Burns had secured a fight-clinching takedown. Della Maddalena followed the knee with a series of elbows on the ground for a TKO victory at 3:43 in the final round of the welterweight bout.

All eyes on the next

Minutes after the fights at UFC 298, CEO Dana White announced the cards for the next big event: UFC 300.

Alex Pereira will defend his UFC light heavyweight title against former champ Jamahal Hill in the main event on April 13 in Las Vegas.

Pereira became the ninth UFC fighter to win a title in multiple divisions when he defeated former light heavyweight champion Jiri Procházka in the second round at UFC 295.

Meanwhile, Hill hasn't fought since January 2023, when he beat Glover Teixeira to capture the light heavyweight crown in an impressive unanimous decision. However, a freak accident during a basketball game that injured his Achilles tendon kept him from defending his belt, eventually leading to the relinquishment of the belt.

Other notable fights include the BMF title bout between Justin Gaethje and Max Holloway, the strawweight title fight between Zhang Weili and Yan Xioanan, and a lightweight contest between Charles Oliveira and Arman Tsarukyan.

Payback time: O'Malley silenced his doubters with a statement win over Marlon Vera via unanimous decision (50-45, 50-45, 50-44). The American not only completed his maiden title defence but did it in some style, outsmarting Vera in every other department. AFF

